

Three Arguments Against Sola Scriptura

Sola scriptura is the Protestant doctrine that the Bible is the sole inerrant authority for Christian faith and practice. It's often assumed to have originated in the early church.

I THE ARGUMENT FROM AVAILABILITY

I — AVAILABILITY: THE BIBLE WASN'T THERE

The Bible as we know it didn't exist until hundreds of years after the birth of the church.

CANON FORMATION

- **No inspired table of contents** — the New Testament canon selection process was fully human, disorganized, and inconsistent. Church leaders scattered across the Roman Empire accepted or rejected writings independently (see next section)
- **Slow** — canon unofficially settled by Athanasius' 39th Festal Letter in 367, but no official decree was ever issued

SIGNIFICANT EXCLUDED WRITINGS

<i>All of the following were considered authoritative by various Christian communities during the earliest centuries of the church.</i>	
WRITING	MANUSCRIPT PRESENCE / NOTES
Gospel of Thomas	Contains 114 sayings of Jesus, but no narrative of his life (no death or resurrection); possibly Gnostic
Gospel of Peter	Strongly anti-Jewish, and possibly Docetic
Acts of Paul	The source of the legendary physical description of Paul (small, bald, big nose, crooked legs)
Acts of Peter	The source of the tradition that Peter was crucified upside down in Rome
Epistle to the Laodiceans	Purportedly the letter Paul references in Col 4:16; popular in the western churches for 1,000+ years
Epistle of Barnabas	Included in Codex Sinaiticus (~350 CE), one of the earliest complete New Testament manuscripts
Apocalypse of Peter	Included in the Muratorian Canon (~180 CE) and Codex Claromontanus (~550 CE); it's a guided tour of heaven and hell with graphic imagery
Shepherd of Hermas	Included in Codex Sinaiticus; quoted as scripture by many 2nd-century church leaders; it seems to be heavily influenced by the Epistle of James
Didache	Quoted as scripture by two 2nd-century church leaders; it's a church manual with instructions about baptism, fasting, prayer, Lord's Supper, treatment of prophets and apostles
1 & 2 Clement	Late-1st-century letters from Bishop Clement of Rome to Corinth; both are in Codex Alexandrinus (~450 CE)

NEW TESTAMENT ACCESSIBILITY TIMELINE

1st–3rd c.	New Testament writings circulate individually; no unified collection
Late 300s	Canon informally settled
400–1400s	Bibles confined to churches and monasteries; population largely illiterate and poor; every copy handwritten
~1450 CE	Gutenberg press invented; Bibles begin reaching privileged people
1517 CE	Luther's Reformation formalizes sola scriptura, but literacy remains low for centuries afterward

BOTTOM LINE

For the first ~70% of Christian history, sola scriptura was practically impossible.

II THE ARGUMENT FROM ANARCHY

II — ANARCHY: THE BIBLE DIVIDES

Widespread Bible availability created a new problem: interpretive chaos with no authoritative resolution mechanism.

THE CHURCH'S STRUCTURAL PROBLEM

- **No systematic dispute resolution** provided in the New Testament — no modern apostles, no binding councils, no courts or judges

THE CHURCH'S PRACTICAL PROBLEM

- **Proof-texting** — plausible opposing texts exist for almost any theological position (both OT and NT); see "Strike 2" in Section III
- **Personal interpretation** — the church's scriptural "constitution" is full of grey areas and confusing theology

OLD TESTAMENT EXAMPLE: DIVORCE

DEUTERONOMY 24:1 — THE KEY WORD: "INDECENCY"		
"...if she finds no favor in his eyes because he has found some <i>indecency</i> in her, that he writes her a certificate of divorce..."		
RABBI	SCHOOL	INTERPRETATION OF "INDECENCY"
Shammai	Conservative	Adultery only
Hillel	Liberal	Any reason the husband deems sufficient

Two of Judaism's most prominent legal scholars couldn't agree on the meaning of a single word, even within a "simple" text.

NEW TESTAMENT EXAMPLE 1: BAPTISM

Is baptism necessary for salvation?	
	SOURCE
YES	Acts 2:38, 1 Peter 3:21, Mark 16:16
NO	1 Cor 1:17, Rom 10:9–10, Luke 23:39–43

NEW TESTAMENT EXAMPLE 2: RIGHTEOUSNESS

Do righteous people exist?		
	SOURCE	NOTES
YES	Matt 9:13/Mark 2:17/Luke 5:32, Mark 6:20, Luke 1:6, Luke 15:7, Luke 23:50, Acts 10:22, Phil 3:6	This is only a partial list
NO	Romans 3:9–10	Loosely references Psalm 14:1–3

BOTTOM LINE

Sola scriptura creates a free-for-all environment in which anyone can interpret scripture without any authoritative guardrails. Consequently, Christianity has fractured into dozens of denominations (and sub-denominations), each claiming scriptural authority.

III THE ARGUMENT FROM AUTHORSHIP

III — AUTHORSHIP: PAUL'S CREDIBILITY PROBLEM

Most of the confusion and divisiveness caused by the Bible has a single source.

STRIKE 1 — FALSE PROPHECY (1 THESS 4:15–17)

1 THESSALONIANS 4:15,17 — EARLIEST NEW TESTAMENT WRITING (~50–51 CE)
"... we who are alive and remain until the coming of the Lord will not precede those who have fallen asleep... we who are alive, who remain, will be caught up together with them in the clouds..."

- Paul asserted he would be alive when Jesus returned, based on receiving "the word of the Lord"
- The New Testament's earliest book thus contains a highly significant failed prediction

STRIKE 2 — PAUL VS. JAMES

WRITER	TEXT	POSITION
Paul	Rom 4:3; Gen 15:6	Justified by faith alone — his entire doctrine is built on one OT verse
James	Jas 2:21–24	"Justified by works and not by faith alone" — direct rebuttal of Paul

- James: Jesus' brother; leader of the Jerusalem believers
- Paul: never met Jesus; self-appointed apostle who didn't have the qualifications defined in Acts 1

STRIKE 3 — PAUL VS. PETER

- Peter: appointed by Jesus (Matt 16:18–19) and given the "keys of the kingdom"; present for Jesus' entire ministry
- Paul: publicly rebukes Peter at Antioch — calls him a "hypocrite" and accuses him of "not acting consistently with the truth of the gospel"
- Even Paul's ministry partner Barnabas sides with Peter
- No biblical record of reconciliation between Paul and Peter

JERUSALEM ENDGAME (ACTS 21 - PAUL'S FINAL VISIT TO THE CITY)

- The issue: the Jewish believers in Jerusalem have heard Paul is anti-Torah and are upset he's in town
- James' plan: urge Paul to undergo a purification rite in the temple to prove he's still Torah-observant
- The plan "fails"; Paul is arrested after his presence in the temple sparks a mob riot

THE AFTERMATH

- James is silent after the arrest: no advocacy for Paul, no prison visits, no support
- Paul is sent to Rome all alone, and his ministry effectively ends
- Notable: James' silence may have spoken volumes

BOTTOM LINE

Sola scriptura is compromised by the fact that a large portion of the New Testament was written by someone who was in conflict with the original apostles during his entire ministry.